



August field: (L-R) Pavel Eljanov, Parham Maghsoodloo, Sanan Sjugirov, Alexandr Predke, Levon Aronian, Pentala Harikrishna, D. Gukesh, Arjun Erigaisi at the inauguration function of Chennai Grand Masters Chess Championship 2023 in Chennai.

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think it is one of the good things about the FIDE Circuit."

With an average rating of 2711, the Chennai Grand Masters was officially the strongest closed invitational tournament held in India, surpassing the previous record set at the AAI International Grandmasters Chess Tournament 2011, which had a rating of 2662.

The tournament's early stages featured surprising twists, with both top seeds, Maghsoodloo and

Erigaisi, stumbling in the inaugural round. Despite this, Erigaisi staged an impressive comeback, matching Gukesh's points at 4.5/7 after seven rounds but losing on tiebreaks.

Gukesh emerged as the winner, earning \$30,000 and a nearly assured spot in the Candidates after surpassing Dutch GM Anish Giri in the FIDE circuit leaderboards.

Giri needed a podium finish at the World Rapid & Blitz Championship 2023 to snatch the spot from Gukesh.

Over in Samarkand, chess maestro Magnus Carlsen asserted his dominance in the shorter time control games, clinching both the Rapid and Blitz titles, taking his overall tally to 17 major championships in a career spanning over two decades.

Gukesh's journey to Canada

became certain after Giri's admirable efforts could only land him in the top 30, way beyond a podium finish in both categories.

It was a double delight for Koneru Humpy, who secured a silver in the Rapid Championship while also qualifying for the Women's Candidates through the rating spot.

The formidable Indian lineup, featuring Gukesh, Vidit, and Praggnanandhaa in the men's section and R. Vaishali and Humpy in the women's category, will make up over 30 per cent of the participants in the upcoming Candidates Tournament in Canada.

This substantial representation highlights India's increasing presence on the global chess scene, foreshadowing a legacy in the making as these players pursue success on the grand stage.